A Permissioned Ledger Framework for Jointly Signed Negotiated Rates Between Providers and Payers

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Abstract

Under two US rules, hospitals and insurers each publish the prices they negotiated, in separate files. A 2026 study of 450 hospitals and two insurers found both sides published the same price for only about 10% of services. We present CORAL, a permissioned ledger on which the provider and the insurer both sign each negotiated price. The record holds the price, the plan, the billing code, its inpatient or outpatient setting, and its dates. Each published file is checked against the records; a price that differs marks the file that departs. Signing and committing one provider's file took 71 minutes on one laptop. Paired on provider and code, five providers' files agreed exactly with one insurer's file on 14.2% of comparable prices; paired on the record's fields, on 30.0%. A synthetic run traces a changed price in either of two copies of the signed values to that copy.

Introduction

Since 2021, each hospital in the United States must publish a machine-readable file of its standard charges, including the rate it negotiated with each payer and plan, under the Hospital Price Transparency rule (45 CFR Part 180) [1]. Since 2022, each group health plan and issuer must publish in-network negotiated rates for every provider under the Transparency in Coverage rule [2]. The two programs publish the same contract terms from two sides (Figure 1a). Each file is produced by one party under its own rule, and no clause of either rule asks the other party to review or confirm it [1, 2]. The hospital attests to its own file under a statement added for CY2024 and replaced for CY2026 [3, 4]; from March 2027 the plan or issuer attests to its file in the same words, under the Transparency in Coverage final rule of October 2026 [5]. Each binds one party to its own file; Executive Order 14221 directs the departments to make the two sets of prices comparable [6].

The two sides do not agree. A 2026 industry report compared the files of 450 hospitals with the files of two national payers on 16 common codes and found that 9.0% of inpatient pairs, 10.8% of gastroenterology pairs, and 11.7% of orthopedic pairs matched exactly; 50.8%, 41.7%, and 47.4% fell within 10%; and 17.9% of inpatient and gastroenterology pairs differed by more than 50% [7]. The comparison cannot say which file is correct, because neither file links a line to a contract version or to the other party.

A negotiated rate is a contract term that two parties agreed. CORAL (Committed Ratesheet on Ledger) is a registry on which a provider and a payer jointly sign each negotiated rate before either publishes it (Figure 1b), so that a published line can be checked against a record neither party wrote alone. The files cite the record; a verifier with a file and read access to the registry checks each line with one lookup, and a line that departs from the record is attributed to the file that departs.

The paper gives the record format, with a key that both public formats map to, and the registry contract, whose key hierarchy judges validity at commit time, rejects backdated revocations, delays root replacement under a veto, and keeps one live record per key. We sign and commit all 262,535 rates of one provider's public file, verify every published line with a standard code and a value, and measure the cost. A second run compares five providers' files with one national payer's file on the 16 codes of the 2026 report, once paired on provider and code as the report did and once on the record key, and traces synthetic alterations of two copies of the signed values to the copy that carries them. Both signatures in every run come from prototype keys, so the runs show cost and coverage, not that any file is correct.

Background

The two files

The provider file, in the CMS tall CSV format, has one row per item and payer plan; the columns that identify a rate and the columns that give its value are the left column of Figure 2 [8]. It must be refreshed at least once a year. The payer file, in the Transparency in Coverage JSON schema, has one item per billing code, with negotiated rates for groups of providers identified by NPI and tax identification number, each with a negotiated type, a billing class, place-of-service codes, modifiers, and an expiration date [9]. It must be refreshed every month; from March 2027 the

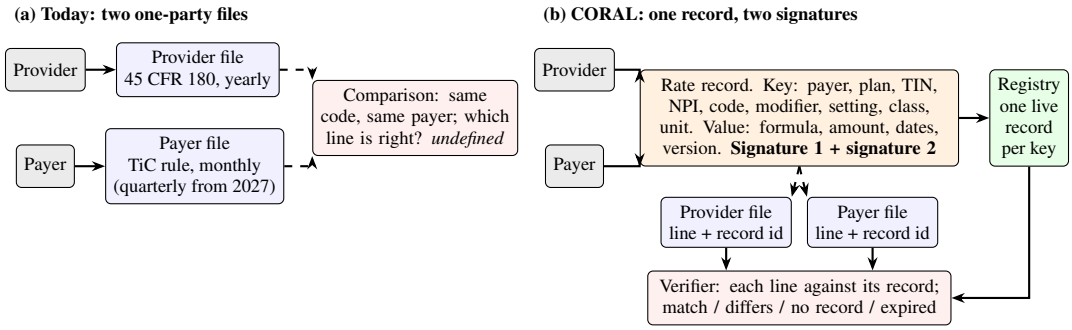


Figure 1: Today a comparison of the two one-party files has no reference to decide which line is right. With CORAL the two parties sign one record per rate, each file cites it, and a verifier checks each published line against it.

file is published per provider network, carries a network identifier, and is refreshed every quarter [5].

What a negotiated rate is

The chargemaster is the provider's list price for every item, set by the provider alone and never negotiated; the CMS file calls it the gross charge. The negotiated rate is a contract term: the price the provider and the payer agreed for one code under one plan, the payer-specific negotiated charge of the CMS file. The record covers three forms of it: a fixed amount, a percent of the chargemaster price, and a percent of a reference fee schedule. In the provider file we profile, 37.7% of the rows that carry a value are percent-of-charges rates, so their dollar value moves whenever the provider changes the chargemaster, which the payer does not sign. Contracts also carry terms the record does not cover: lesser-of-charges clauses, outlier and stop-loss provisions, carve-outs at a percent of invoice, tiered per diems, bundled and capitated payment, and escalators.

Why the files disagree

The identifying fields do not line up: the provider file has setting where the payer file has place-of-service codes, the provider file has a drug unit and the payer file has none, and plan names are free text on one side and plan clusters on the other. Each file is a snapshot with one date, the refresh cycles differ, and contracts change mid-year. The provider file holds many items under one billing code, with different list prices and sometimes different fixed amounts, and a percent-of-charges line gives a dollar result that depends on the chargemaster version in force when the file was built.

Related work

Price transparency. Sinaiko and Rosenthal, and later Mehrotra and colleagues, set out what price publication can and cannot change [10, 11]. Gondi and colleagues and Jiang and colleagues measured early and national hospital compliance with the rule [12, 13]. Wang and colleagues found Transparency in Coverage prices consistent with other commercial sources [14]. Henderson and Mouslim cross-validated one regional insurer's file with 26 hospitals' files on maternity codes: 16.3% of hospital-code combinations appeared in both files, and where both had a price, 77.4% agreed to the cent and 84.4% fell within 10% [15]. An industry comparison counts a match at under 0.5% variance and finds contract escalators behind uniform offsets [16]; payer inpatient coverage is often minimal [17]; checked against remittance payments, under 30% of payments had a concordant published price in either file [18]. Two advocacy and industry groups publish recurring reports on file availability and quality [19, 20]; the 2026 comparison is the direct motivation for this paper [7]. Every one of these studies works from files that a single party produced.

One-party attestation and two-party estimates. The CY2024 OPPS final rule added an affirmation statement to the hospital file [3]; the CY2026 rule replaces it with an attestation that names a senior official, replaces the estimated allowed amount with percentile allowed amounts from remittance data, and adds the hospital's Type 2 NPIs to the file [4]. The October 2026 Transparency in Coverage rule adds the same attestation to the payer file [5]. Each binds one party to its own file only. The No Surprises Act's good faith estimate and advanced explanation of benefits move a price estimate from provider to plan to patient for one visit [21], carried in FHIR by the HL7 Da Vinci Patient Cost Transparency guide [22]; it is a two-party exchange, but per visit, and neither party signs the other's figure.

Ledgers in health care. Kuo, Kim, and Ohno-Machado give the conditions under which a ledger adds value over a database: several parties that do not trust one operator, a shared need for an append-only history, and no acceptable

neutral host [23]. Claims and directory networks on permissioned ledgers exist: a national clearinghouse's claims network on Hyperledger Fabric [24], a payer consortium's provider directory [25], a practitioner credentials exchange [26], and a smart-contract store for insurance records [27]. What each holds is a fact that one party asserts.

Transparency logs. Certificate Transparency [28, 29], Trillian [30], and the IETF SCITT architecture [31] give an append-only log under one operator with proofs of inclusion; PeerReview [32] and SUNDR [33] detect a log operator that shows different histories to different readers. Zieglmeier shows that an append to a chain proves the sender's action and not the counterparty's receipt [34]; CORAL answers this with the counterparty's signature inside the record. A one-operator log would serve CORAL if the parties accepted one operator; the Discussion returns to this.

Methods

The record

A rate record has a key and a value (Figure 2). The key is the set of fields that identify one rate; two records equal on all key fields are the same rate. The value gives the formula (fixed, percent of charges, or percent of reference), the amount in cents or basis points, the start and end dates, a contract version label, a reference version (the chargemaster or fee-schedule version a percent rate applies to), and the id of the record this one supersedes, if any.

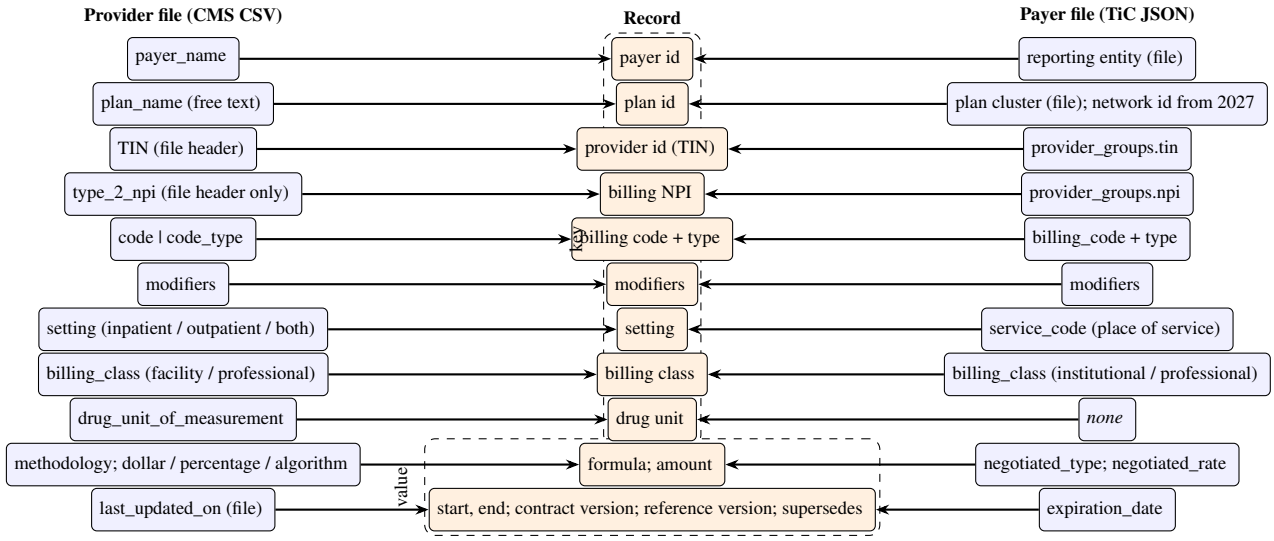


Figure 2: The rate record and where each field comes from in the two public formats. The contract version and the supersedes link exist in neither file.

The setting and billing class fields come from the CMS file; the payer file's institutional class maps to facility, and the provider file carries its NPIs in the header only, so the provider side keys at the TIN and the file's first NPI. Version 2.0 of the payer schema adds a setting field to each price [9]; in payer P's file it reads "both" on 78.5 million of 78.7 million prices, so the parser reads setting from the place-of-service codes where they are present: 21 is inpatient; 19, 22, 23, and 24 are outpatient. An institutional price carries no place of service: a DRG is inpatient, and any other institutional price is taken as applying in both settings, as the CMS file's "both" does; a professional price with no place of service is counted as unknown. The payer file has no drug unit.

Entity, Delegation, Revocation, and Chargemaster Version records support the rate record. An Entity binds an entity id to a root public key. A Delegation authorizes a signing key for an entity over a time window. A Revocation ends a signing key from a time at or after the block that carries it. A Chargemaster Version is the provider's signature over a version label, the SHA-256 of the chargemaster file, and an effective date; a percent-of-charges record names it, so that a verifier can recompute the dollar result from a signed list price. The prototype verifier takes the list price from the line under test and compares the percent; resolving the version to the committed file is not built.

Identity and keys

The provider's identity root is its tax identification number, because contracts are signed at that level and the payer file carries it; a system with several TINs holds one root per TIN. The payer's root is the party that holds the contract,

an issuer or, for self-funded plans, the administrator or network owner that contracts on their behalf, identified by the HIOS issuer id or its EIN, the two identifiers the payer file schema allows; the national health plan identifier was rescinded in 2019 [35], and the network identifier of the October 2026 rule is the natural plan id for the record [5]. The registrar binds an entity id to a root key once, after out-of-band proofing, and never signs a rate (Figure 3). Neither rule sends a file to a regulator: each party posts its file on its own site, CMS enforces the hospital rule, and HHS, Labor, and Treasury enforce the Transparency in Coverage rule, with states as primary enforcers for issuers [2]. The registrar needs identity proofing only, which CMS already does for hospitals and issuers, so the prototype makes CMS the registrar.

Each entity holds one root key offline and delegates one or more signing keys to the system that produces its rate sheet, for many providers a vendor's system; the delegation is on the registry and a revocation ends it. The root signs delegations and revocations only and cannot be delegated as a signer, so it cannot sign a rate. A verifier answers "was key K authorized for entity E at time T" from the registry alone.

Validity is judged at the block timestamp of the commit, a time that consensus sets within the block period and the signer cannot choose. A revocation must take effect at or after the block that carries it, so a root cannot backdate a revocation to before a record its signing key committed; records committed before a revocation stand. Root replacement after loss is proposed by the registrar, takes effect after seven days, and the current root can veto it during that window with its signature. Loss is covered and theft is not: a holder of a stolen root can veto its own replacement, and a registrar override after a longer delay is a design we have not built.

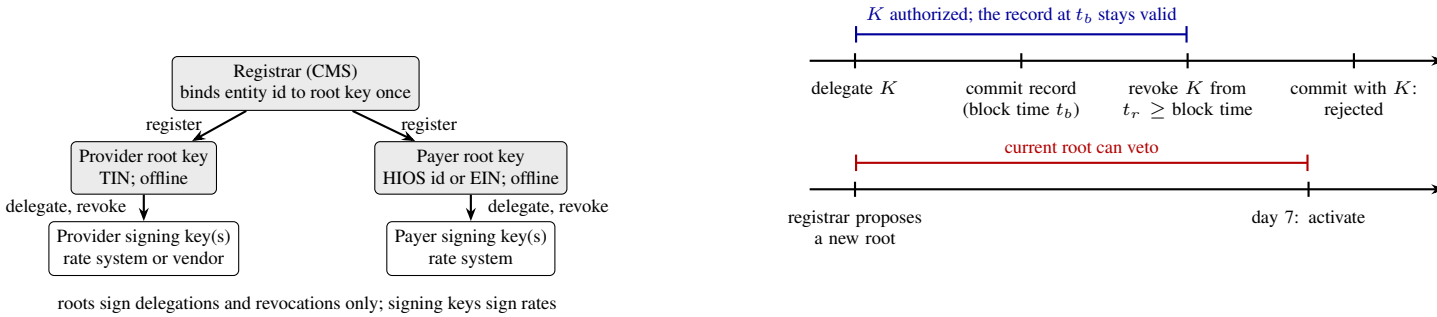


Figure 3: Keys and time rules. Left: the registrar binds each entity to a root; roots delegate signing keys. Right: validity is judged at block time; a revocation cannot start before its block; root replacement waits seven days under a veto.

The registry

The registry is one contract on a permissioned Ethereum-compatible network (Figure 4). Each action carries EIP-712 typed-data signatures [36], which show the signer the fields; the domain binds the chain id and contract address, so a signature for one deployment is not valid on another. Both parties sign the same structure hash, and that hash is the record id. Identifier fields are 32-byte strings; a longer identifier is stored as its hash, and the published file must carry the full text. Anyone can relay the transaction, and the relayer has no authority. Records commit one at a time or in a batch that succeeds or fails as a whole.

One record is live per key at any time. A new record for a key whose window overlaps a live record is rejected, unless it names that record in its supersedes field; the old record then ends where the new one starts. At any block height a verifier finds one answer for one date; a superseding record may start in the past, so a verdict is reported as of a block height and can change when a later record supersedes.

The prototype network is Hyperledger Besu 26.10.2 with IBFT 2.0 consensus [37], a two-second block period, and four validators, which stand for CMS, a provider association, a payer association, and an auditor. Validators order transactions; they cannot sign a rate. In every run all four validators ran in containers on one laptop with a 10-core ARM processor and 64 GB of memory, under Besu's enterprise profile, which keeps full state history; the throughput figures therefore carry no network latency and include archive storage. Two defects found in review after the runs are fixed and tested: a signed revocation for a later time could be replayed to reopen a key, so a revocation now only moves earlier; and a record whose window had ended could be superseded and so extended, now rejected. A root can no longer be delegated as a signer, and a veto is bound to one proposal. No fix adds storage, and every run below ran on the fixed contract from a fresh ledger. Read access in the prototype is open to any node; a deployment sets it as policy.

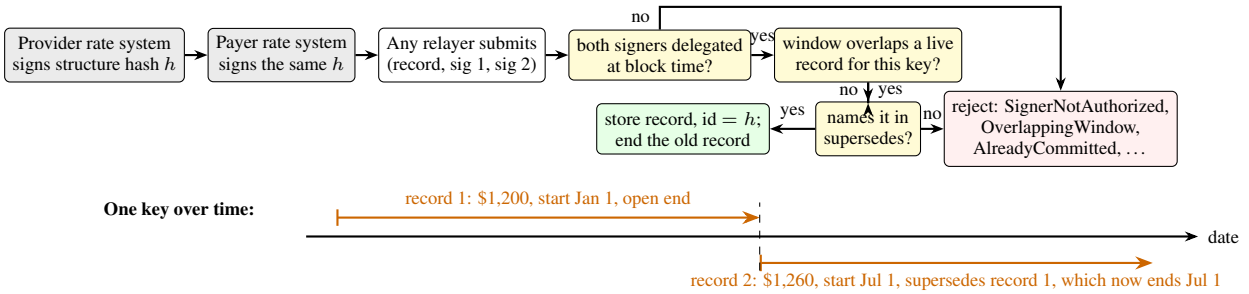


Figure 4: Commit path and supersession. The contract checks both signers against delegations at block time, rejects an overlapping window unless the new record names the live one, and keeps one live record per key.

Verification

A verifier reads the registry once into an index by key, then checks each published line with one lookup; Figure 5 gives the verdicts. For a fixed rate the expected amount is the signed value. For a percent-of-charges rate it is the signed percent of the list price for that code, setting, and unit; a provider line that publishes the percent is compared on the percent, and a line that publishes only the dollar result is compared on the dollar recomputed from the list price the line carries. When both files are verified, a pair of lines resolves to both match the record, payer file departs, provider file departs, both depart, or unsigned. The two files alone give no such verdict.

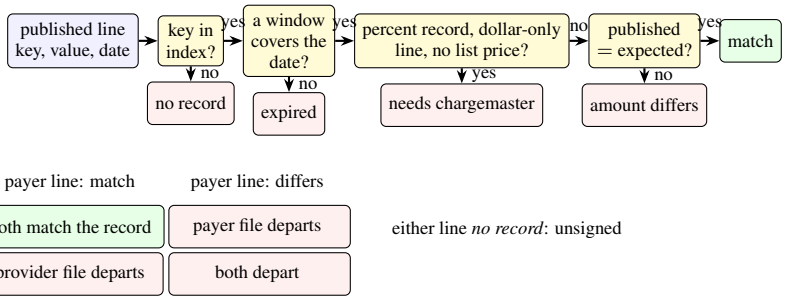


Figure 5: Verdict for one published line (top) and for a pair of lines from the two files (bottom). A difference between the files is attributed to the line that departs from the signed record.

Evaluation design

Full-sheet run. We take the public file of provider A, a hospital in Colorado (file dated 2025-11-01; CMS format 3.0.0, which the file declares a month before CMS posted the format). Providers are lettered A to E in this paper; payers are not named. Every payer named in the file is registered with prototype keys. Every row with a percentage becomes a percent-of-charges record that names a signed chargemaster version; every other row with a dollar amount becomes a fixed record; rows with only an algorithm are counted. One record is signed per key, from the first row in file order; a later row with the same key and a different value is a key collision and is counted. We then verify every row with a standard code and a value against the registry, and again after altering 1% of those rows in the field the record signs, the percent on a percent-of-charges row and the dollar otherwise; a changed dollar result on a percent-of-charges row is not a change to the signed term and is not checked.

Pair run on real data. We take five providers' files (Table 2) and one Transparency in Coverage in-network file of a national commercial payer, payer P (one plan cluster, dated 2026-10-05, 547 plans, 1.69 GB compressed). For each provider we keep the rows for payer P's commercial plans on the 16 codes of the 2026 report and map the file's plan name to one label; the crosswalk is manual and listed in the code, and maps every commercial plan of the cluster to that label because the provider file names the product line, not the plan. Provider B's file carries a second commercial product line, a leased-network product that a third party administers, which the main run leaves out because a leased network is outside the record (Limitations); its effect is reported as a sensitivity. From the payer file we keep prices for the five providers' NPIs on the same codes, pooled under one NPI per provider, so the pairing is at the TIN level (provider E lists eight NPIs); the parser dropped 79 professional prices with no place of service and took 24 institutional prices as applying in both settings. We pair the files twice: on provider and code alone, as a comparison without the record key must, every provider line for a code against every distinct payer value for that provider and

Table 1: Full-sheet run cost: one provider file, 20 payers, prototype keys on both sides, one run from a fresh ledger.

Records signed (fixed / percent of charges)	262,535 (201,394 / 61,141)
Signing, both sides, final run	685 s (766 signatures/s)
Commit, 100 records per transaction	74 records/s (59.3 min for the sheet)
Transaction input per record	834 bytes (219 MB in the run)
Validator storage per record / for the sheet	24,070 bytes / 6,319 MB
Clean copy: match / amount differs / needs chargemaster	349,258 / 14,006 / 426
Altered copy: rows altered / caught / already differed / not comparable	3,584 / 3,454 / 128 / 2

code; and on the record key, every provider line against every distinct payer value of its key, with the nearest value of the same kind as a secondary measure, since a key has several payer values when several plans in the cluster price it. Each measure reports exact match, within 10%, and more than 50% apart over the pairs where both sides give the same kind of value.

Synthetic attribution. For each paired key with a provider dollar amount we sign one record with that amount as the agreed value, with prototype keys on both sides. We then build two copies of the signed value, one labeled provider and one labeled payer, alter each line of each copy independently with probability 0.1 by $\pm 10\%$, $+50\%$, or -50%, verify both copies, and report the attribution of each difference. Both copies start from the record, so the run is a functional test of the attribution step and says nothing about real agreement; the payer never agreed the signed value.

Key rotation. On the running network we commit a record with a payer signing key, delegate a new key, revoke the old one, and repeat the commit with each key; we then attempt a backdated revocation, a root replacement before its delay, and a root replacement after a veto.

Discovery. We record how many provider files could be found and parsed. The CMS locator file (`cms-hpt.txt`) at each provider's domain names the file.

All code, the contract, the parsers, the run output, and the contract tests (twenty) are in the repository [38].

Results

Full-sheet run

The file has 633,324 rows (Figure 6a). 165,513 carry only a chargemaster, revenue, or NDC code and no code both parties use, so they are outside the record format; the remaining 467,811 rows name 20 payers, and 104,121 of them give an algorithm and no dollar or percent value. The 363,690 rows with a value reduce to 262,535 records, 201,394 fixed and 61,141 percent of charges: 86,723 rows repeat the key and value of an earlier row, and 14,432 rows carry a different value for a key already signed, on 14,292 keys that hold 30,636 rows between them. These are items with the same billing code, setting, class, and unit but a different list price and a different fixed amount, which the key fields of the public formats do not separate; the key therefore fails for 4.0% of the rows with a value, the record on such a key holds the first row's value, and a key extended with the provider's item code would separate them.

Table 1 gives the cost. The run committed 262,525 records to a ledger that held the ten example records of the repository. Signing ran at 766 signatures per second. Commits ran 100 records per transaction with eight transactions in flight, at 74 records per second over the run, and the rate fell as the ledger grew (Figure 6b): 154 records per second over the first 20,000 records of the run and 56 over its last 50,000; the configured block period is two seconds, and the run averaged 3.4 s per block, so the validators were execution-bound. The sheet took 59.3 minutes to commit and 11.4 to sign, and added 6,319 MB to each validator.

Verification of the clean file returned 349,258 matches, 14,006 amount-differs verdicts, and 426 needs-chargemaster verdicts; both kinds are the key collisions. In the altered copy, 3,584 rows had their signed value changed; 3,454 changed from match to amount differs, 128 were collision rows that differed before the change, and 2 were needs-chargemaster rows; no altered row that matched before the change matched after it, as the construction guarantees. This run is self-consistency: the records were minted from the rows they are checked against. It establishes that the record format covers every row with a standard code and a value, that the key holds for all but 14,432 rows, and the cost of signing a full sheet.

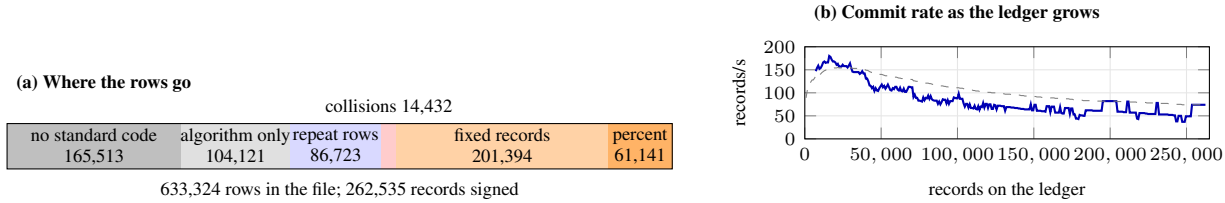


Figure 6: Full-sheet run. (a) Of 633,324 rows, those with a standard code and a value reduce to 262,535 signed records; repeat rows carry the key and value of an earlier row, collisions carry a different value for a key already signed. (b) Commit rate over windows of 6,400 records (solid) and cumulative (dashed); the rate fell from 154 records per second over the first 20,000 records to 56 over the last 50,000.

Table 2: Five providers against payer P's file on the 16 codes of the 2026 report, paired on the record key, every provider line against every payer value of its key. Keys: distinct record keys on each side. Comparable: both sides give the same kind of value. Percentages are of comparable pairs.

Provider	File date	Codes	Provider keys	Payer keys	Pairs	Comparable	Exact %	Within 10%	Over 50%
A (Colorado)	2025-11-01	0	0	44	0	0	–	–	–
B (Colorado)	2025-11-01	16	19	73	47	31	35.5	58.1	6.5
C (Illinois)	2026-11-03	8	8	16	8	8	37.5	100.0	0.0
D (Oregon)	2026-03-23	16	46	24	24	10	0.0	100.0	0.0
E (California)	2026-04-01	8	8	18	3	1	100.0	100.0	0.0

Discovery

Of ten health systems tried on 2026-10-27, four served the CMS locator file; of ten tried on 2026-11-03, four served a tall CSV, four JSON, one a wide CSV, and one an empty archive, and our parser reads the tall CSV only. One national payer publishes files of 9 GB and more per plan, which we did not download; payer P publishes 5,697 in-network files by plan cluster of about 1.7 GB each, with no state in the name. The pair run therefore covers one payer.

Pair run on real data

Payer P's file lists 468 prices for the five providers' NPIs on the 16 codes, 232 after lines with the same key and value are merged. Paired on provider and code alone, the files give 226 pairs, 106 with the same kind of value on both sides; of those, 15 (14.2%, 95% interval 9–22%) matched exactly, 53.8% fell within 10%, and 35.8% differed by more than 50%. Paired on the record key, every provider line against every payer value of its key, there are 82 pairs, 50 comparable, of which 15 (30.0%, interval 19–44%) matched exactly, 74.0% fell within 10%, and 4.0% differed by more than 50% (Table 2). The payer file rounds to ten cents, so 27 of the 50 agree within five cents. A paired key has 1.53 payer values on average; against the nearest value only, 33 comparable pairs give 45.5% exact and 97.0% within 10%, an upper bound. Provider A has no pair: its rows for payer P on the 16 codes are all under a Medicare Advantage plan, which the Transparency in Coverage rule does not cover. The sample is small, 50 comparable key pairs from four providers, of which provider B gives 31. With provider B's leased-network product line included, the key pairing gives 20.3% exact, 50.0% within 10%, and 18.9% over 50% on 74 pairs, and the provider-and-code pairing 7.0% exact on 214; with repeat provider lines removed, the key pairing gives 28.3% exact on 46.

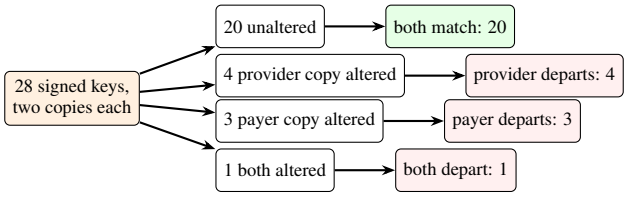


Figure 7: The synthetic run: every altered copy is attributed to its side, and every unaltered pair matches the record on both sides.

Synthetic attribution

28 paired keys had a provider dollar amount; one record was signed for each, and two copies were built (Figure 7). The planned 10% alteration touched 5 provider copies and 4 payer copies under seed 7: 4 keys had only the provider copy changed, 3 only the payer copy, and 1 both. Verification attributed 4 differences to the provider copy, 3 to the

payer copy, and 1 to both; the 20 unaltered keys matched the record on both sides. The construction guarantees this outcome; the run shows that the verifier delivers it.

Key rotation

On the running network, a record was committed with the payer's signing key, a new key was delegated, and the old key was revoked from ten seconds after the current block. After that time a commit with the old key reverted with `SignerNotAuthorized` and the same commit with the new key succeeded; `authorizedAt` returned true for the old key at the commit time of its earlier record and false after the revocation, so the earlier record stays valid. A backdated revocation reverted with `BackdatedRevocation`, a root activation before its delay with `RootDelayNotPassed`, and an activation after the root's veto with `NoPendingRoot`; the root was unchanged. Activation after the seven-day delay is covered by the unit tests, which move the clock, and was not run on the network.

Discussion

The record format holds every row of a real provider file that carries a standard code and a value, 363,690 of 633,324 rows. The key fields of the public formats identify a rate for all but 14,432 rows, on 14,292 keys; those are items that share a billing code, which the provider file knows by chargemaster code and the payer file does not know at all, and a comparison that pairs by code and payer alone meets them as several provider values for one payer value. Signing and committing a full sheet took 71 minutes on one laptop, loading the registry into a verifier takes 804 s, and verifying the file against the loaded index takes 1.1 s.

The pair run against the 2026 report. Paired on provider and code alone, the same five files and payer P's file give 14.2% exact, 53.8% within 10%, and 35.8% over 50%, within a few points of the report's exact and within-10% figures, with a higher over-50% share (35.8% against 17.9%). Paired on the record key, the same lines give 30.0% exact, 74.0% within 10%, and 4.0% over 50%. The difference is measured on the same files: when the lines are paired on the fields the record carries, the over-50% share falls from 35.8% to 4.0% and the exact share doubles, and 50 minus 15 key pairs still differ. The sensitivities hold the direction. Three cautions apply: the sample is 50 comparable key pairs from four providers against one payer, so each percentage moves by two points per pair; the nearest-value measure picks the best of 1.53 values and is an upper bound; and what remains after pairing on the record key is what a signed record would attribute to one file, which no run here does with a counterparty's signature.

Scale. About 6,000 hospitals, each with a sheet of this size, give 1.6 billion records; at the measured 24,070 bytes per record and 74 records per second that is about 38 TB per validator and 247 days of commits, before any payer-side record, and the rate was still falling. The per-record storage and the fall in rate are consistent with the archive state the enterprise profile keeps and with storage measured before compaction; neither was profiled, and a pruned profile was not measured. The prototype stores the whole record on chain; the bodies are already in the public files, so a deployment can store the record id and the two signatures only, which we have not built or measured, and the overlap check still needs the key hash and window on chain.

Why a replicated ledger. Kuo and colleagues' conditions apply: providers, payers, and CMS each produce their own record of the same term; the history must be append-only, because a rate that changes mid-year must keep its earlier record; and no party is accepted by the others as the operator of the record. A CMS-run signed log with a hash chain would give the same inclusion guarantee, and a per-record transparency log under one operator would give both of the ledger's conveniences, one record per change and lookup by key, with no consensus layer; a lighter design still signs one Merkle root per sheet per contract version, with an inclusion proof per published line. The ledger removes no trust assumption that the registrar already carries; whether its replication is worth having, and whether the regulator should operate the log, are governance questions this paper does not settle. Table 3 gives the trust model as built. The registrar is a single point of trust for identity binding, limited by the delay and veto: it cannot sign a rate, remove a record, or re-key an entity without a week's notice. Three of four validators can reorder or rewrite history, and two can halt the chain; a deployment needs more validators, drawn from parties with opposed interests, or witness checkpoints of the chain head.

Privacy and market effects. Every validator reads every record in plaintext. The rates are public once published, but a record is committed before publication, so a validator run by a payer or provider association sees a competitor's amendments and their timing early; a deployment therefore sets read access as policy and can hold the record body off chain, though the key hash and window stay on chain and the key fields are public identifiers, so the hash is reversible. A shared ledger of rates among competitors also raises the questions any exchange of price data among competitors

Table 3: Trust model of the prototype: what each actor can do and what the registry prevents or detects.

Actor	Can do	Prevented or detected
Rate signer (either party)	sign any value for its side	cannot commit alone; record needs the counterparty's signature
Signing-key holder (vendor)	sign within the delegation window	revocation from block time; records before it stand
Thief of a root key	delegate new keys; veto root replacement	loss is recoverable, theft is not (no registrar override)
Relayer	submit, delay, or withhold a signed record	no authority; either party can resubmit; a signed draft has no deadline (limitation)
Registrar	bind a root; propose a replacement	cannot sign a rate or remove a record; replacement waits seven days under a veto
One validator	see every record; propose blocks in turn	cannot forge a signature; timestamp bounded by the block period
Block proposer (one block in four)	order the transactions of its block	a stolen-key commit can precede the revocation in the same block; not prevented
Three of four validators	reorder or rewrite history	not prevented; needs more validators or external witnesses
Registrar key compromise	bind false roots; propose replacements	no registrar rotation; needs a redeployment

raises.

Adoption. The second signature does not exist today. The hospital rule could require that a reported rate cite a jointly signed record, as the CY2024 and CY2026 rules added and extended the affirmation statement [3, 4], and enforcement under 45 CFR 180.90 already covers hospital file content; the payer side needs the three departments that issue the Transparency in Coverage rule. A payer has its own reason to ask for the record as a contract term, as a defense against a provider file that overstates a rate, and a provider association could run the registry for its members and invite payers. Where they do not agree a value, no record exists, both lines verify as no record, and the files carry the disagreement in the open. A record signed with a stolen key stands until both parties sign a superseding record.

Limitations. Both signatures in every run come from prototype keys, so no run shows that a file is correct, only that a file matches the record it was minted from; the synthetic run tests attribution on two copies of the signed value. The record carries a contract version and a start date that no public file holds, so the runs set them to one label and one date. The record covers fixed, percent-of-charges, and percent-of-reference rates and not the other contract terms listed in the Background; algorithm-only rows (104,121 here) and leased networks are outside it. The hospital rule covers hospitals, and the Transparency in Coverage rule does not cover Medicare Advantage or Medicaid managed care, so for those rates only one side publishes. The pair run covers one payer, five providers, and 16 codes, after a manual plan crosswalk and TIN-level pooling, on a payer file whose setting field reads "both" on nearly every price, and the provider files are dated between 2025-11-01 and 2026-11-03 against a payer file dated 2026-10-05, so part of the disagreement can be a rate update. A national reproduction first needs a parser for the JSON provider format, a way to handle payer files of 9 GB and more, and the network-level files of 2027. The registry cannot detect a rate that both parties signed wrongly.

Conclusion

On one real provider file the record format covers every row with a standard code and a value, the key holds for all but 14,432 rows, and signing and committing the sheet took 71 minutes on one laptop. On five providers and one payer, on the 16 codes of the 2026 report, the files agree exactly on 14.2% of comparable pairs when paired on provider and code and on 30.0% when paired on the record key, so the large disagreements the report measures lie mostly in the fields the record carries, and the rest is what a signed record would attribute to one file. With a jointly signed record behind each rate, a verifier attributes a difference to the file that departs from the record, as the synthetic run shows on two copies of the signed values; no comparison of the two files can do that today.

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